POWER BUILDING



Cheat Sheet & Additional Resources

JUSTICE OUTSIDE · STAFF REFERENCE · 2026

DEFINITION

The intentional and strategic practice of resourcing grassroots leaders to share wisdom, co-create strategies, and drive collective impact. The goal: communities most affected by environmental injustice make the decisions that govern their land, water, and outdoor spaces.

Shorthand. *"We don't fund projects. We fund power."*

WHAT POWER-BUILDING IS AND ISN'T

Power-building can sound abstract until you have to explain it to someone who has never heard the term. Use this to keep it concrete.

POWER-BUILDING IS ✓

- A practice. Not a program with a start and end date.
- An ecosystem. Each pillar makes the others stronger.
- A transfer of decision-making power to communities most affected by environmental injustice.
- The thread connecting everything we do, in every department.
- Long-term. Relational. Compounding.

POWER-BUILDING IS NOT ✗

- Just grantmaking. We move money, but money is one input in a larger cycle.
- Just programs. Fellowships and learning labs alone do not shift power.
- Just advocacy. Policy wins without funding and leadership development do not compound.
- Service delivery. We are not helping communities. We are resourcing leaders who already know what their communities need.
- A campaign. It does not end.
- DEI work. It is environmental justice work. The two are not the same.

When in doubt, return to this: power-building is community wisdom, resourced and connected at scale.

HOW TO TALK ABOUT THIS

Every Justice Outside staff member should be able to answer four questions clearly. These are the building blocks. Your department training guide builds on top of them.

1. What does Justice Outside do?

We are a national environmental justice intermediary led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. We move flexible, trust-based funding to community-led grassroots organizations. We coordinate advocacy that moves community priorities into policy. We develop the leaders and networks shaping the future of the environmental movement.

2. What is power-building?

The intentional and strategic practice of resourcing grassroots leaders to share wisdom, co-create strategies, and drive collective impact. Our goal is for the communities most affected by environmental injustice to make the decisions that govern their land, water, and outdoor spaces.

3. Why does this matter right now?

Communities of color are three times more likely to live in nature-deprived areas in the United States. 74 percent of people in those areas are communities of color. The need is documented. The model is proven. Our work is built to change this.

4. How do we know it works?

Independent evaluation by Bowman Performance Consulting found that 96 percent of our grantee partners report improved financial stability through our trust-based approach. 95 percent describe our process as co-designed and supportive. In 2025, we moved more than $4 million to 180+ community-led organizations across 7 regions.

The shorthand worth memorizing: "We don't fund projects. We fund power."

"When I think about what we are building together, I think about the people who have been doing this work for decades without the resources or recognition they deserve. They are why we exist. Every grant we move, every campaign we run, every leader we develop is in service of what they already know.

Power-building is not a strategy we invented. It is a practice we learned by listening. Our job, in every department, on every team, is to keep listening. To keep resourcing. To keep building.

When you trust people and resource them well, they show up. They adapt. They lead. We saw that in 2025, in a year that tested everything. The cycle gets stronger every year because we do this work together." - *Kim Bailey, President and CEO*

ADVOCATE

We change who makes decisions about our natural world.
What it looks like: Coalitions, advocacy hubs (CA/WA/PA), national campaigns, biennial conference

FUND

We resource community leaders so they can lead.
What it looks like: Flexible, renewable, trust-based grants ranging from $10,000 to $40,000, no 501(c)(3) required

BUILD

We grow the leaders who will transform this movement.
What it looks like: Rising Leaders Fellowship, Network for Network Leaders, Pathfinders, Learning Labs

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2025 BY THE NUMBERS

$4M+ moved to **180+** community-led organizations across **7 regions** · **58 fellows** from 52 organizations in 15 states · **200+** changemakers at Unite & Ignite

Nature Gap: **3x** more likely for communities of color to live in nature-deprived areas · **74%** of people in those areas are communities of color

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Say this ✓	Not this ✗
• We advocate with communities, not for them	• Speaking for communities
• Trust-based, flexible, renewable funding	• Beneficiaries, recipients, awarded grants
• Grantee partners, community-led	• Voiceless or empowering communities
• National environmental justice intermediary	• Underrepresented (use “overlooked by traditional philanthropy”)
• Power-building (over “DEI” or “diversity”)	• DEI funding, diverse grantees
• Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (spelled out)	• Driving change (we resource it; communities drive it)